

IELTS Speaking

IMPROVE YOUR
LANGUAGE FOR
BANDS 7.0+

The Essentials

Banglay IELTS

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

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ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— HOMETOWN

- What's (the name of) your hometown?
- Is it a big city or a small town?
- Describe your hometown a little?
- How long have you been living there?
- What do you like (most) about your hometown?
- Is there anything you dislike about it?
- Do you think you will continue living there for a long time?
- Has your hometown changed much since you were a child?
- Are there any changes you would like to make in your hometown?

What's the name of your hometown? It's called _____ and it's located/situated in...	Is it a big city or a small town? It's a relatively big city, I guess. It's a medium-sized town.	Describe your hometown a little It's a densely populated (or a sparsely populated) place.	Most residents live in residential areas on the outskirts of the city. In the heart of the city/town, it's a shopper's paradise.
There are a number of places of interest such as...	I would highly recommend visiting...	How long have you been living there? I've been living there since birth/ for roughly ____ years.	Is there anything you dislike about it? Like all cities, there is traffic congestion at peak times so I get annoyed when I get stuck in traffic.
Do you think you will continue living there for a long time? I'm hoping to go to... I'm not entirely sure, who knows what the future will bring...	Has your hometown changed since you were a child? Yes, it's radically changed... No, there have been minor changes but it's still pretty much the same.	Are there any changes you'd like to make? If I had the chance, I'd change/get rid of/increase the number of...	What is it famous for? It's renowned for its cuisine. Some of its famous dishes include...

Fail to prepare, prepare to fail!

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— HOMETOWN

Glossary

to be located in/situated in	to be in a particular place
to highly recommend visiting	to strongly recommend visiting
medium-sized	of average size
relatively	regarded in comparison with something else; quite
densely populated	lots of people live there
sparsely populated	not many people live there
a residential area	a place where people live
on the outskirts of	the outer parts of a town/city
a shopper's paradise	a great place for people who like shopping
roughly	about
traffic congestion	very little or slow movement of traffic
at peak times	at the busiest times of day e.g. 8-9am and 5-6pm
to get stuck in traffic	the traffic has stopped and you can't move
to radically change	to change a lot
minor changes	small changes
pretty much the same	almost the same
to get rid of	to remove
to be renowned for	to be famous for
dishes	food

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— WORK

If the examiner asks: ‘**Do you work or are you a student?**’

You answer:

Yes, I work.

But there is nothing in this answer to impress the IELTS examiner so develop it...

I’m currently working for _____



Using the **Present Continuous** here will add to your Grammatical Range, which is 25% of your overall grade for IELTS Speaking

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— WORK

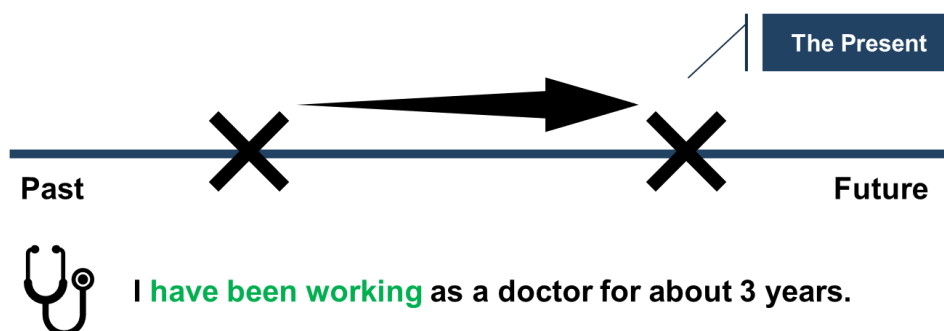
If the examiner asks: 'What do you do?'

You answer:

I'm _____

Again, there is nothing in this answer to impress the IELTS examiner so develop it...

Present Perfect Continuous (have + been + verb + ing)



Now you try:

Insert your own
answers in here

I _____ (work) as a _____ for about _____ years.

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— WORK

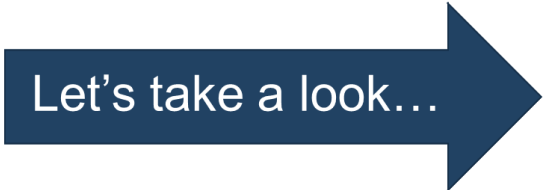
Another question might be: **‘Do you like your job?’**

You answer:

 Yes, I like my job

YOU ARE REPEATING THE WORDS FROM THE QUESTION!!!

You need to use more complex language...



Let's take a look...

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— WORK



Oh yes, I **absolutely love** my job.

Absolutely! I **love every minute of** my job.

Oh yes I do. I **have nothing to complain about. As jobs go**, it's great.

As _____ go (plural noun)
= compared to the average or typical one



To be honest, I **can't stand** my job.

Quite frankly, I **don't particularly enjoy** my job.

To be perfectly honest, I'm **not that keen on** my job.

What do you like/dislike about your job?



No two days are the **same** so I like the **variety and unpredictability**.

My **workmates** - they're all really **chilled** but incredibly **supportive** so there's a **great atmosphere**.

It may sound **materialistic**, but the **pay and the perks**. It's a **well-paid job with a company car**.



It's a **dead-end job** with **no career prospects**.

I do the same thing **day in day out** so it's **mind-numbingly boring**.

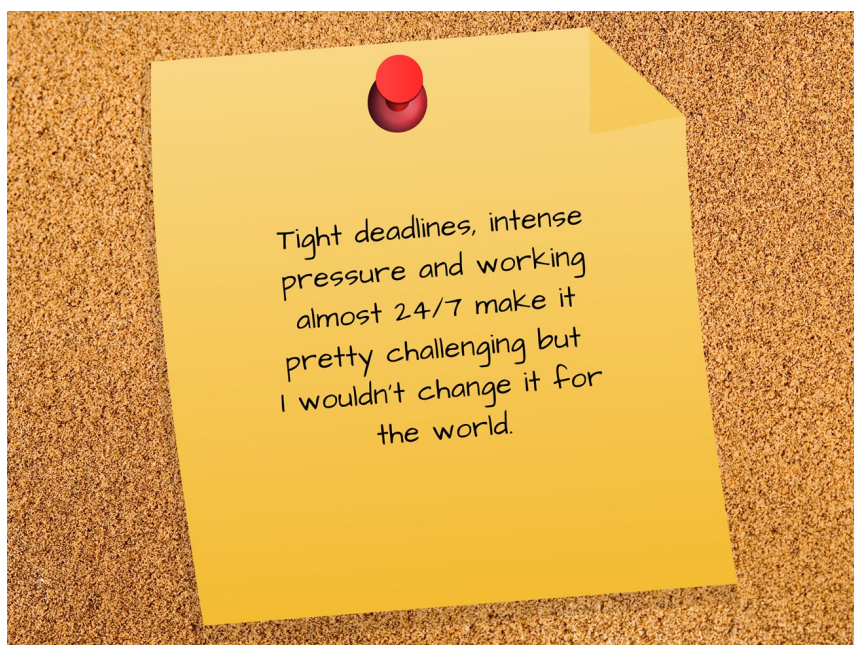
It's impossible to have any **work-life balance** because of my **heavy workload**.

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— WORK

I've been doing it for roughly ____ years	If I had worked harder at school, I might have become a _____	As jobs go it's pretty good so I can't complain	It's a job that's hard to switch off from, but I do enjoy it
It's a pretty intense job and some days can be quite draining to be honest	It's not a job for life , but it pays pretty well and it's not that taxing so it's alright	Like most jobs it has its ups and downs but on the whole it's not too bad	I can work flexitime so it's convenient and fits around the school runs
Feeling appreciated – my boss always gives positive feedback	It's incredibly stressful and challenging so I feel drained by the end of the day	It's rewarding so I get a great sense of satisfaction	It's hard to climb the career ladder so the career prospects aren't great

Make sure that you know lots of **complex words/phrases** that could be used to talk about your job.



ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— WORK

Glossary

to have nothing to complain about	to have nothing to be unhappy about
the variety	lots of different things to do
unpredictability	lots of changes rather than the same thing
chilled	relaxed
materialistic	money-oriented; obsessed with money and goods
the perks	something extra given to you in your job
a company car	a car given to you to do your job
a dead-end job	no chances of promotion
no career prospects	no promotion possibilities
day in day out	every day
mind-numbingly boring	very boring
work-life balance	the amount of time you spend doing your <i>job</i> compared with the amount of time you spend with your <i>family</i> and doing things you enjoy
to have a heavy workload	to have lots of work to do
to switch off (from)	to stop thinking about something
pretty intense	it requires quite a lot of thought or effort
draining	It takes all of your energy and leaves you feeling tired
a job for life	a job that you will do until you retire
taxing	Demanding and tiring; difficult and needing a lot of thought or effort
to have its ups and downs	a mixture of good and bad things
on the whole	generally

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— WORK

Glossary

to work flexitime	you can change your start and finish time
convenient	suitable/good for you
to fit around	to be able to do it alongside other things
the school run	taking your children to and collecting your children from school
to feel appreciated	to feel valued; to feel that you are important
my/the boss	my/the manager
to give positive feedback	to say nice things about your work
challenging	difficult
to feel drained	to feel really tired and have no energy
rewarding	satisfying/pleasing
a great sense of satisfaction	a good feeling
to climb the career ladder	to get a better, usually higher-paid job
career prospects	chances of getting a better job
tight deadlines	you don't have long to do something
intense pressure	a lot of stress
24/7 (we say 24 7)	all day, every day
I wouldn't change it for the world	I wouldn't want to do anything else

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— STUDY

If the examiner asks: **‘Do you work or are you a student?’**

You answer:

I’m a student.

But there is nothing in this answer to impress the IELTS examiner so develop it...

I’m currently studying at _____



Using the **Present Continuous** here will add to your Grammatical Range, which is 25% of your overall grade for IELTS Speaking

If the examiner asks: **‘What are you studying?’**

You answer:

I’m studying _____

But you can develop it further...

Present Perfect Continuous (have + been + verb + ing)

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— STUDY



Now you try:

Insert you own
answers in here

I _____ (study) _____ for about _____ years.

Another question might be: 'Do you like your studies?'

You answer:

Yes, I like my studies

YOU ARE REPEATING THE WORDS FROM THE QUESTION!!!

You need to use more complex language...

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— STUDY



Oh yes, I **absolutely love** my course.

Absolutely! I **love every minute of** my studies.

Oh yes I do. I **have nothing to complain about. As courses go**, it's great.

As _____ go (plural noun)
= compared to the average or typical one



To be honest, I **can't stand** my course.

Quite frankly, I **don't particularly enjoy** my course.

To be perfectly honest, I'm **not that keen on** my course.

What do you like/dislike about your studies?



No two days are the same so I like the **variety and unpredictability**.

My **classmates** - they're all really **chilled** but incredibly supportive so there's a **great atmosphere**.

The lecturers are **engaging** and **bring the subject to life**.



The lectures are **mind-numbingly boring** to be perfectly honest.

I chose the wrong major and I'm **bored to death** most of the time.

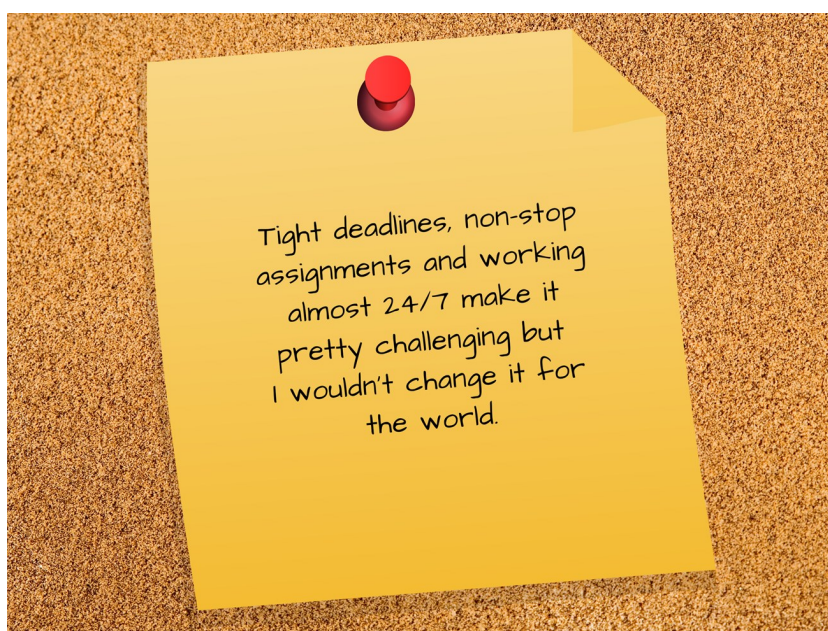
I don't have any **downtime to hang out with my mates** because of my **heavy workload**.

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— STUDY

I've been studying it for roughly ____ years	If I had worked harder at school, I could have studied _____	As courses go it's pretty good so I can't complain	It's a course that's hard to switch off from, but I do enjoy it
It's a pretty intense course and some days can be quite draining to be honest	It's not taxing and they set pretty generous deadlines	Like most courses it has its ups and downs but on the whole it's not too bad	There are not many face-to-face classes so I can work part-time as well
Feeling supported – my professor always gives positive feedback	It's incredibly stressful and challenging so I feel drained by the end of the day	It's a great mix of practical and theory classes so no two days are the same	My classmates are a right laugh and incredibly supportive

Make sure that you know lots of complex words/ phrases that could be used to talk about your studies.



ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

PART 1— STUDY

Glossary

to have nothing to complain about	to have nothing to be unhappy about
the variety	lots of different things to do
unpredictability	lots of changes rather than the same thing
chilled	relaxed
engaging	interesting
to bring the subject to life	to make it real or exciting
mind-numbingly boring	very boring
to be bored to death/tears	to be very bored
downtime	time when you are not working
to hang out with my mates	to spend time with your friends
to have a heavy workload	to have lots of work to do
to switch off (from)	to stop thinking about something
pretty intense	it requires quite a lot of thought or effort
draining	it takes all of your energy and leaves you feeling tired
taxing	demanding and tiring; difficult and needing a lot of thought or effort
to set pretty generous deadlines	to give you quite a long time to do the work
to have its ups and downs	a mixture of good and bad things
on the whole	generally
face-to-face classes	in the classroom — not online
to feel supported	to be given help and encouragement when needed

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION

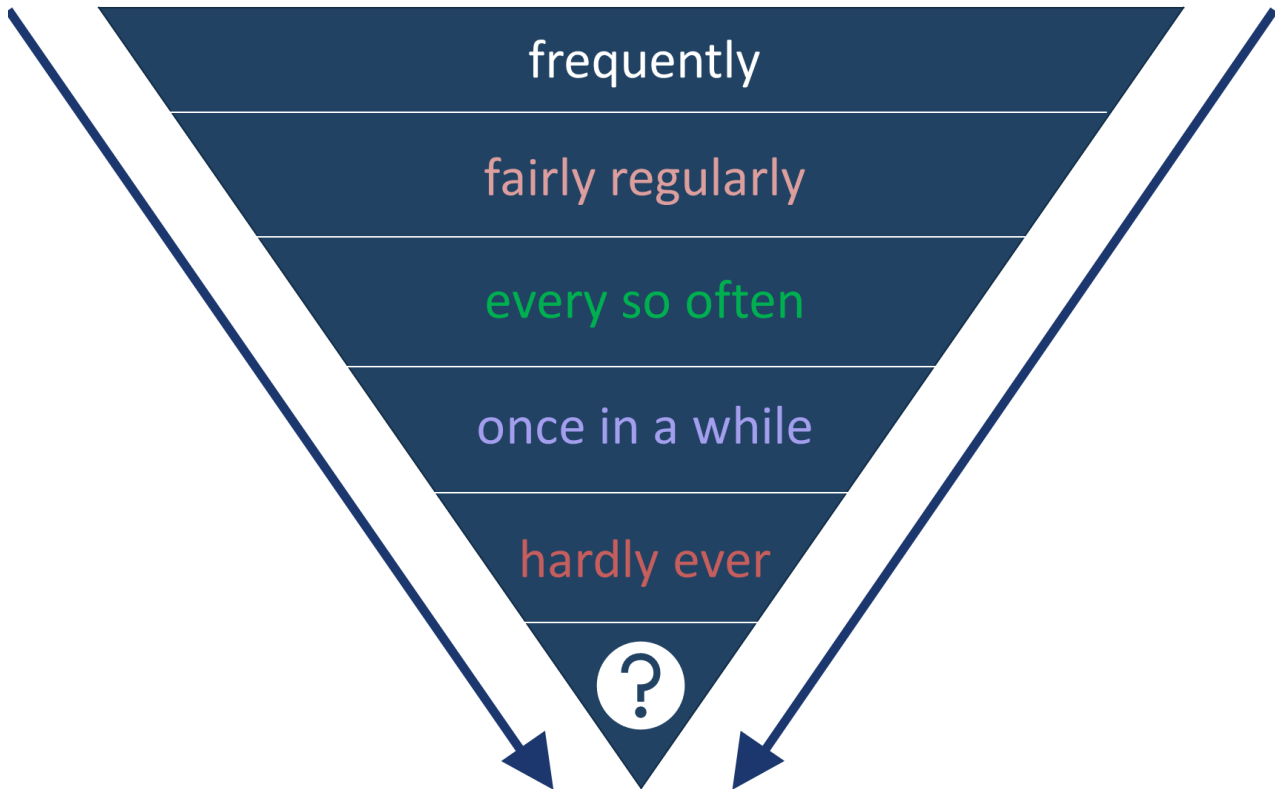
PART 1— STUDY

Glossary

to give positive feedback	to say nice things about your work
challenging	difficult
to feel drained	to feel really tired and have no energy
a great mix of	a combination of; a mixture of
practical classes	classes where you do things
theory classes	classes where you study things
no two days are the same	every day is different
a right laugh	good fun
supportive	encouraging and helpful

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1 — HOW OFTEN...?



Look at the following model answer and note how adverbs of frequency have been used...

1. How often do you send emails?

Nowadays, I only send emails **every so often**. I used to send them **fairly regularly**; however, now I tend to only send them **once in a while**.

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — DESCRIBING PEOPLE

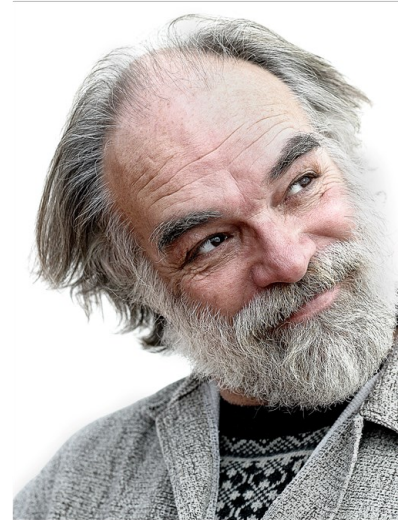
Age



She is
in her early twenties

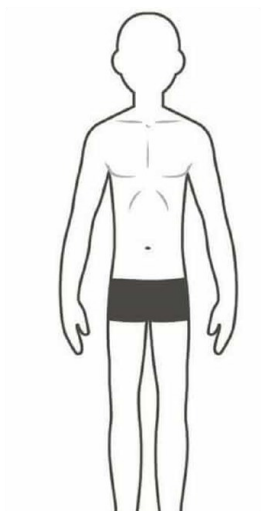


He is
in his mid forties

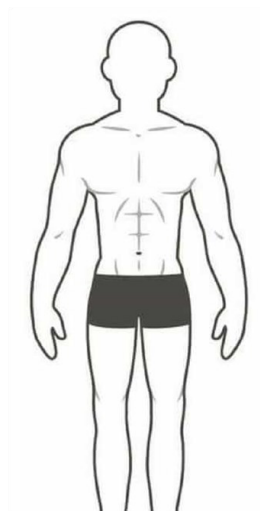


He is
in his late sixties

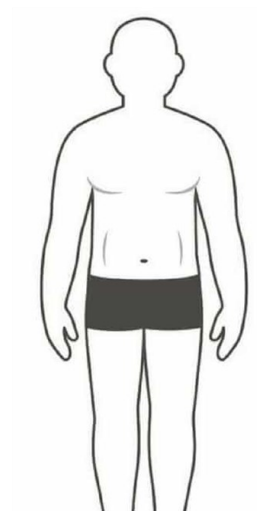
Looks



He/She has
a small build



He/She has
a medium build



He/She has
a large build

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — DESCRIBING PEOPLE

brilliant ambitious selfish gentle obnoxious
vulgar noisy sensitive sensible
naughty mysterious wonderful mean
malicious unsure lazy jealous
cynical dangerous truculent deceitful cruel
timid crazy honest clumsy helpless
boring grumpy hard-working arrogant
shambolic anxious slow silly interesting
arrogant abrupt entertaining wise enthusiastic
witty productive proud wonderful excited
protective vivacious patient neat efficient
mature discreet talented bossy demanding
determined logical absent-minded lively friendly
kind-hearted spiritual confident skilful sincere
attentive aggressive bright brave adventurous pessimistic
practical depressed imaginative intuitive emotional

intuitive

ability to understand something based on feelings

witty

funny in an intelligent way

kind-hearted

kind, caring and sympathetic

vivacious

lively and fun to be with

absent-minded

forgetful or pre-occupied

discreet

cautious, reserved, modest, careful

logical

looks at the facts and knows they could be wrong

sincere

honest, genuine

To be a people person	Someone who is good with people
To be head and shoulders above the rest	Someone who is better than other people
To be a charismatic leader	Attractive and inspirational to others
To be full of beans	Someone who has lots of energy
The life and soul of the party	Someone who likes having fun

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — DESCRIBING PEOPLE

Phrase	Meaning and Example
To be good company	To be an interesting person to spend time with
She's such good company and time passes so quickly when I'm with her.	
To have a good heart	To be kind and caring
He has a good heart and will help anyone who needs it.	
To be a laugh a minute	To be very funny
She's a laugh a minute and she lifts my mood/spirits* when I spend time with her.	

*You start to feel happier when you are with them

WHICH ONE ARE YOU?

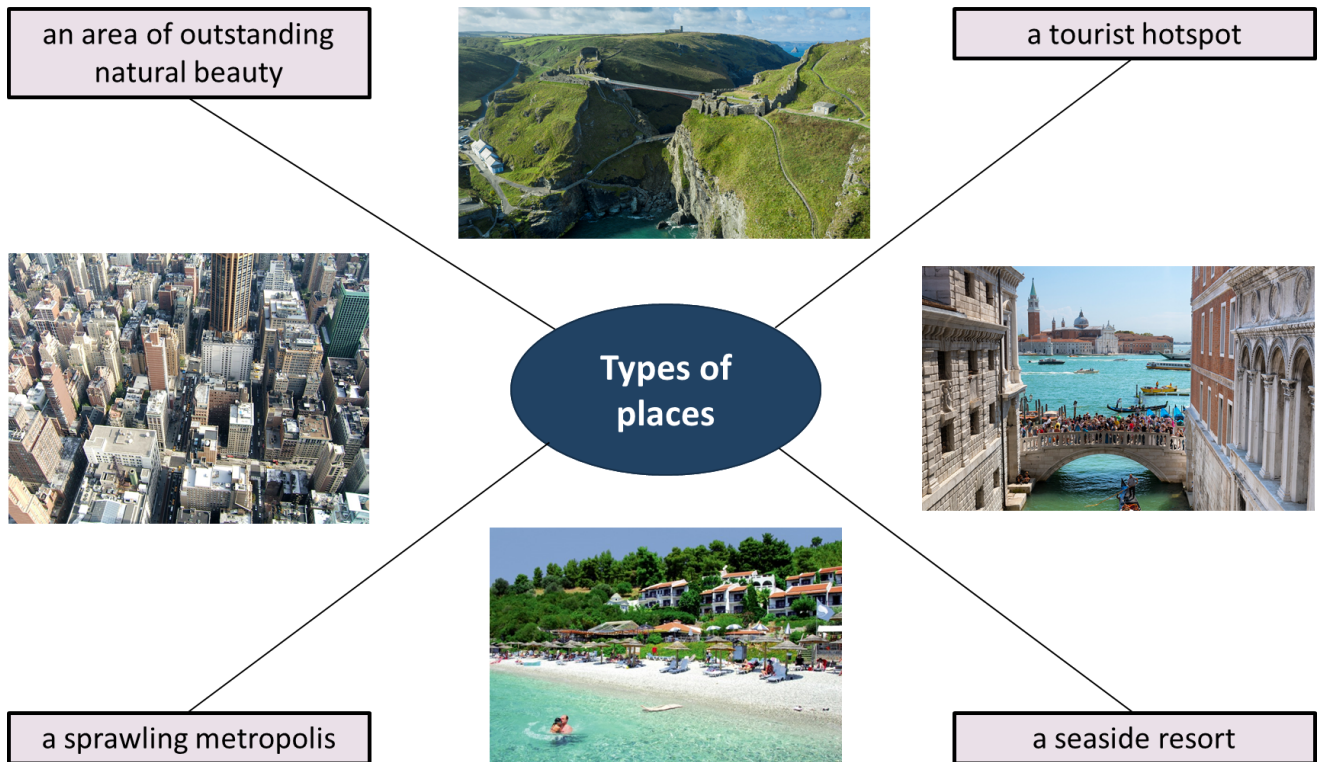
a glass half-empty person
is a **pessimistic** person



a glass half-full person
is an **optimistic** person

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — DESCRIBING PLACES



picturesque – as pretty as a picture



stunningly beautiful, charming and quaint

a concrete jungle



full of ugly grey buildings and a lack of green spaces

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — DESCRIBING PLACES

a rural backwater



an isolated place in the middle of nowhere

a shopper's paradise



a must for shopaholics and window shoppers

fancy cafes and upmarket restaurants



They tend to be overpriced/pricey and cost an arm and a leg/cost a fortune

takeaways and fast-food outlets



Take out/carry out for a quick bite to eat

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — DESCRIBING PLACES

**bustling, vibrant, lively,
thriving**



**tranquil, idyllic, a tourist
hotspot**



**overcrowded and teeming with
people**

a picture-postcard place

It's worth visiting because it's... It's not worth visiting because it's...



**a historical place with
stunningly beautiful architecture**



**run-down and full of graffiti
and derelict buildings**

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — DESCRIBING PLACES

Glossary

outstanding	very good
sprawling	spreading out over a large area in an irregular way
a metropolis	the capital or main city of a country or region
a hotspot	a popular place
seaside	near the sea
resort	a place where people often go on holidays
picturesque	very beautiful (only for places)
stunningly beautiful	very beautiful (can be used for people as well)
charming	pleasant and attractive
quaint	attractively unusual or old-fashioned
a concrete jungle	full of buildings and no green spaces
ugly	not beautiful
a lack of	not enough of
rural	in the countryside
backwater	An isolated or peaceful place; a place or situation in which no development or progress is taking place e.g. the country is an economic backwater.
isolated	far away from other places, buildings, or people; remote
in the middle of nowhere	far away from other places, buildings, or people; remote
a shopper's paradise	a great place for people who like shopping
a must	something that is very good and should not be overlooked or missed
shopaholics	people who are addicted to/love shopping
window shoppers	looking at things in shop windows but not buying

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — DESCRIBING PLACES

Glossary

fancy (adj.)	sophisticated; expensive
upmarket	sophisticated; expensive; posh
overpriced/pricey	too expensive
to cost an arm and a leg/a fortune	to cost a lot of money
to take out/to carry out	to take away
a (quick) bite to eat	to have a small meal
an outlet	a shop
bustling	busy
vibrant	full of energy and life
lively	full of energy and life
thriving	flourishing; doing well economically
to be teeming with	to be full of
tranquil	calm, quiet, and peaceful
idyllic	calm, quiet, and peaceful
architecture	buildings
run-down	in a poor and bad condition
graffiti	writing on walls or buildings as a form of artistic ex-
derelict	empty and in a very poor condition

USEFUL PREPARATION

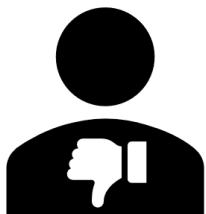
PART 1, 2 AND 3 — LIKES AND DISLIKES



Oh yes, I **absolutely love** music.

Absolutely! I'm **really into** art.

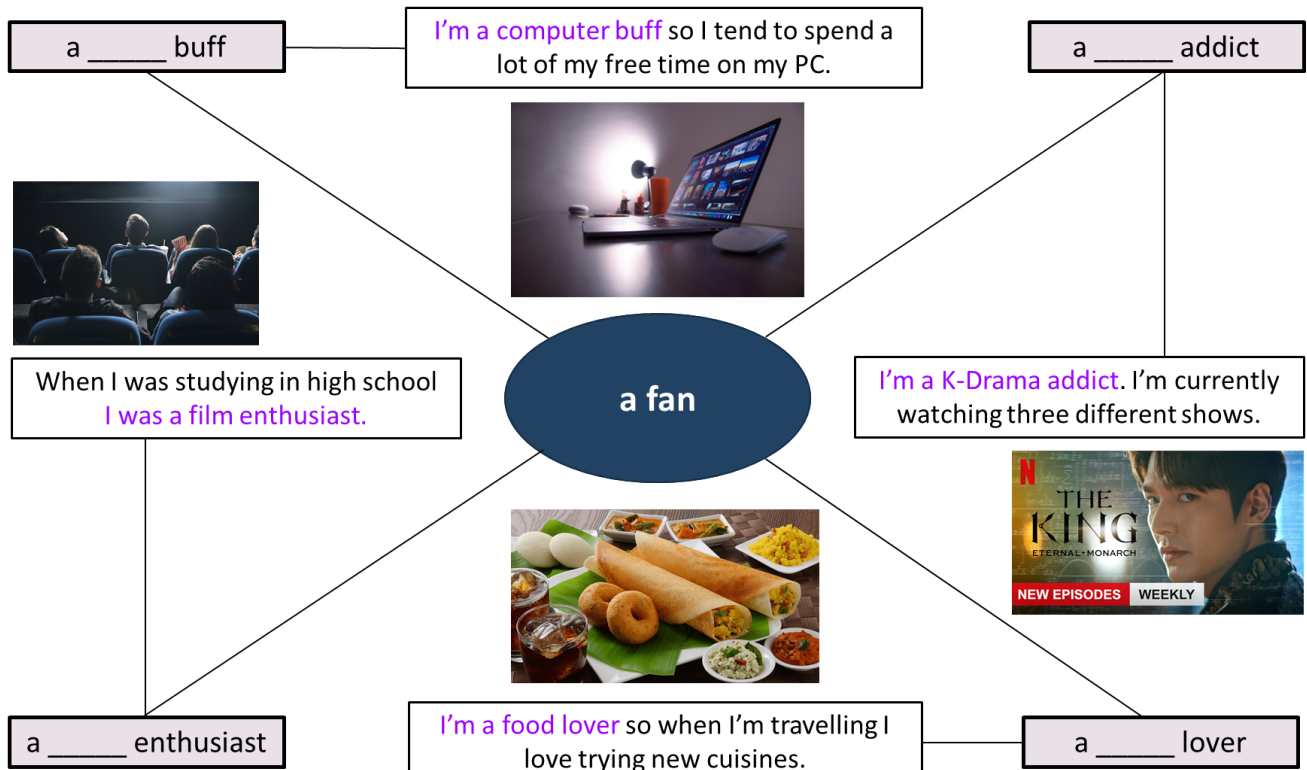
Oh yes I do. I **can't get enough of** travelling.



To be honest, I **can't stand** football.

Quite frankly, I **don't particularly enjoy** going to the cinema.

To be perfectly honest, I'm **not really into** cooking.



USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — LIKES AND DISLIKES

Adjective		Meaning	Example
avid		having or showing a keen interest in or enthusiasm for something	I'm an avid reader and carry my kindle around with me so I can read at every opportunity.
keen		having or showing eagerness or enthusiasm	I'm a keen runner and try to go for a run four or four times a week if possible.
enthusiastic		having or showing intense and eager enjoyment, interest, or approval	I'm an enthusiastic cook but I wouldn't describe myself as a particularly good one.
passionate		having, showing, or caused by strong feelings or beliefs	I'm a passionate supporter of Man Utd. I'm elated if they win and devastated if they lose.

Adjective		Meaning	Example
reluctant		not willing to do something and therefore slow to do it	I'm a reluctant gym-goer . I force myself to go, but I'm really not keen.
unwilling		not ready, eager, or prepared to do something	I'm an unwilling cinema-goer . It's pricey and the drinks and snacks are a rip-off .
unenthusiastic		not having or showing intense and eager enjoyment, interest, or approval	I'm an unenthusiastic cook – I tend to cook tasteless and boring meals.
half-hearted		without enthusiasm or energy	I'm a half-hearted runner. I do it but I don't push myself as much as I should.

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — LIKES AND DISLIKES

Adjective + preposition	Meaning	Example
to be obsessed with	having or showing a keen interest in or enthusiasm for something	I'm obsessed with a Korean group called BTS so I've been learning Korean for a few years.
to be keen to	having or showing eagerness or enthusiasm	I'm keen to learn the piano, but my heavy workload doesn't give me time to practise.
to be enthusiastic about	having or showing intense and eager enjoyment, interest, or approval	I'm enthusiastic about cooking, but I'm not a particularly good cook.
to be passionate about	having, showing, or caused by strong feelings or beliefs	I'm passionate about Liverpool FC and never miss a game.

Adjective + preposition	Meaning	Example
to be indifferent to	having no particular interest or sympathy; unconcerned	I'm indifferent to art so I've never even set foot in an art gallery.
to be not bothered about	showing or feeling no interest, enthusiasm, or concern	I'm not bothered about politics and don't pay a lot of attention to it.
to be unenthusiastic about	not having or showing intense and eager enjoyment, interest, or approval	I'm unenthusiastic about travelling. I go on holiday but I'd rather stay at home.
couldn't care less about	not at all concerned about it; it doesn't matter to you	I couldn't care less about sport. I have zero interest in it and never watch it on TV.

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — LIKES AND DISLIKES

I'm a huge/massive fan of _____	If I had more time, I'm sure I'd be into _____, but I'm time-poor at the moment.	_____ really appeals to me but I've never had the chance to do it.	I can't bear _____
I have zero interest in _____	I can take or leave _____	What I especially/particularly love about _____ is...	What I especially/particularly detest about _____ is...
I'm not so/too keen on _____	I'm quite fond of _____	I'm (a bit/very) partial to _____	_____ is my guilty pleasure



USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — LIKES AND DISLIKES

Glossary

supporter	fan
elated	very happy
devastated	very sad
_____goer	A person who goes to... e.g. a cinema-goer
to force yourself to do something	to make yourself do something
pricey	expensive
a rip-off	something that is not worth what you pay for it
tasteless	to have no taste; bland
to have a heavy workload	To have a lot of work to do
to set foot in	to go into
to pay attention to something	to take notice of something
to have zero interest in	to have no interest in
to be time-poor	to not have enough time to do things
To appeal to e.g. it really appeals to me	I like it
I can't bear/I can't stand	I hate
I can take or leave _____	you don't care where you have it/do it or not
to detest	to hate
to be partial to	to like
a guilty pleasure	an activity or piece of media (e.g. song/film etc) that someone enjoys but would be embarrassed by if other people found out about it

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 2 — THE 'WHEN' BULLETPOINT

USING THE PAST CONTINUOUS

was/were + verb+ing

For example:

I was studying

I was living

I was working

I was travelling

To be perfectly honest,
I can't remember
precisely/exactly when
it was, but it was
when I was studying in
high school.



OR

To be perfectly frank, I
haven't got a clue*
when it was, but I'm
pretty sure it was
when I was travelling
around Europe a few
years back.



*to have no knowledge about something, or
to be unable to remember something

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 2 — THE 'WHEN' BULLETPoint

Phrase	Meaning and Example
To slip my mind	To forget
As for when it was, I'm not entirely sure... it's slipped my mind, but it was a few years ago.	
To remember rightly	We use this expression to say that we think that we can remember something correctly, but we are not 100% sure
If I remember rightly, it was last June.	
At a guess	what you are saying is only an estimate or what you believe to be true, rather than being a definite fact
I can't remember for certain when it was but at a guess, in was in 2017.	

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 2 — THE 'HOW YOU FELT ABOUT IT' BULLETPoint

How you felt about a good experience...

To have a whale of a time

To enjoy yourself very much



- It was great to catch up with my mates and I had a whale of a time.
- It was such a fascinating and amazing place and I had a whale of a time.
- It was incredibly tiring but I had a whale of a time.

Prepare for {IELTS}

How you felt about a bad experience...

To be a nightmare

To be an extremely unpleasant event or experience



- It was an absolute nightmare at the time, but now I can laugh about it.
- It was a bit of a nightmare at the time, but I quickly got over it*.
*To get over something = to recover from something
- It was a total nightmare to be perfectly honest, but these things happen.

Prepare for {IELTS}

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 2 — THE 'HOW YOU FELT ABOUT IT' BULLETPoint

How you felt about a surprising/good/bad experience...

To be lost for words

To be shocked and not know what to say



- As you can imagine, at the time I was lost for words because I didn't expect it.
- When I heard the news I was lost for words. Honestly, I was totally astounded.
- It's hard to sum up how I feel about her/him I'm lost for words, to be perfectly honest,

Prepare for {IELTS}

How you feel about a person...

To take your hat off to him/her/them

To admire someone for what they have achieved



- As for how I feel about her, well she juggles* two children and is the CEO of a multinational company so I take my hat off to her.

*to juggle = to succeed in arranging your life so that you have time to involve yourself in two or more different activities or groups of people

- It's hard to sum up how I feel about him. I take my hat off to him because he's an incredibly successful person and he works extremely hard.

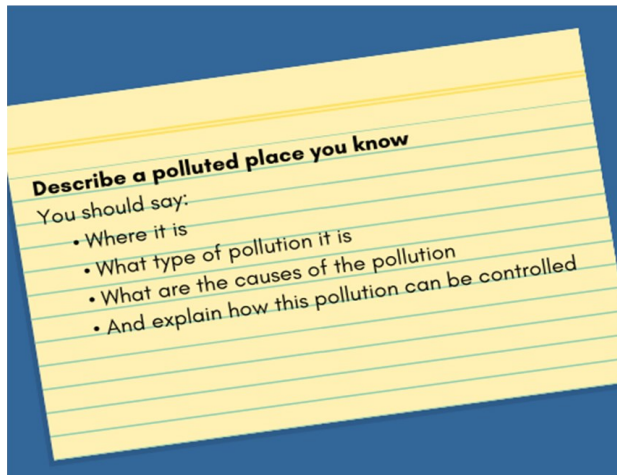
Prepare for {IELTS}

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — USEFUL GRAMMATICAL FILLER PHRASES

Present Perfect

To describe past actions in an unspecified time:
subject + has/have + past participle



I hope I've covered everything.

I hope I haven't missed anything.

Present Continuous

To describe continuous actions in the present:
subject + am/is/are + verb + ing



Mmmm...I'm struggling to think of a good answer, but anyway, I guess...

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — USEFUL GRAMMATICAL FILLER PHRASES

Past Continuous

To describe continuous actions in the past:
subject + was/were + verb + ing



Oh **what was I saying...**

oh yes, that was it...

Present Perfect Continuous

To describe actions that started in the past and continue in the present:
subject + have + been + verb + ing



I've been trying to remember/think of...

I've been racking my brains* to remember/think of...

To rack your brains = to think very hard about something

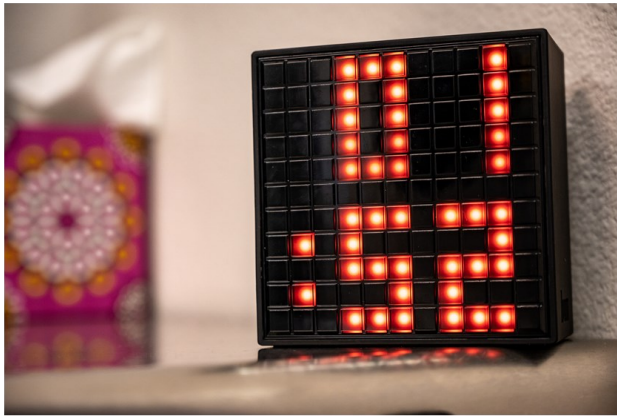
USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — USEFUL GRAMMATICAL FILLER PHRASES

Second Conditional

To describe imaginary things in the present:

If + subject + past simple, subject + would + infinitive



If I **had** more time, I **would go** into it in more detail, but basically...

Oh, that's a tough question and I've never really thought about it before. I suppose **if pushed**, I'd **have to say**...

Third Conditional

To describe imaginary things in the past:

If + subject + past perfect, subject + would + have + past participle



Sorry, that wasn't a very detailed answer. If I'd **had** more time to think, I **could have given** a better one.

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — USEFUL GRAMMATICAL FILLER PHRASES

I wish/If only

To talk about a present situation we would like to be different:

I wish/If only + subject + past simple

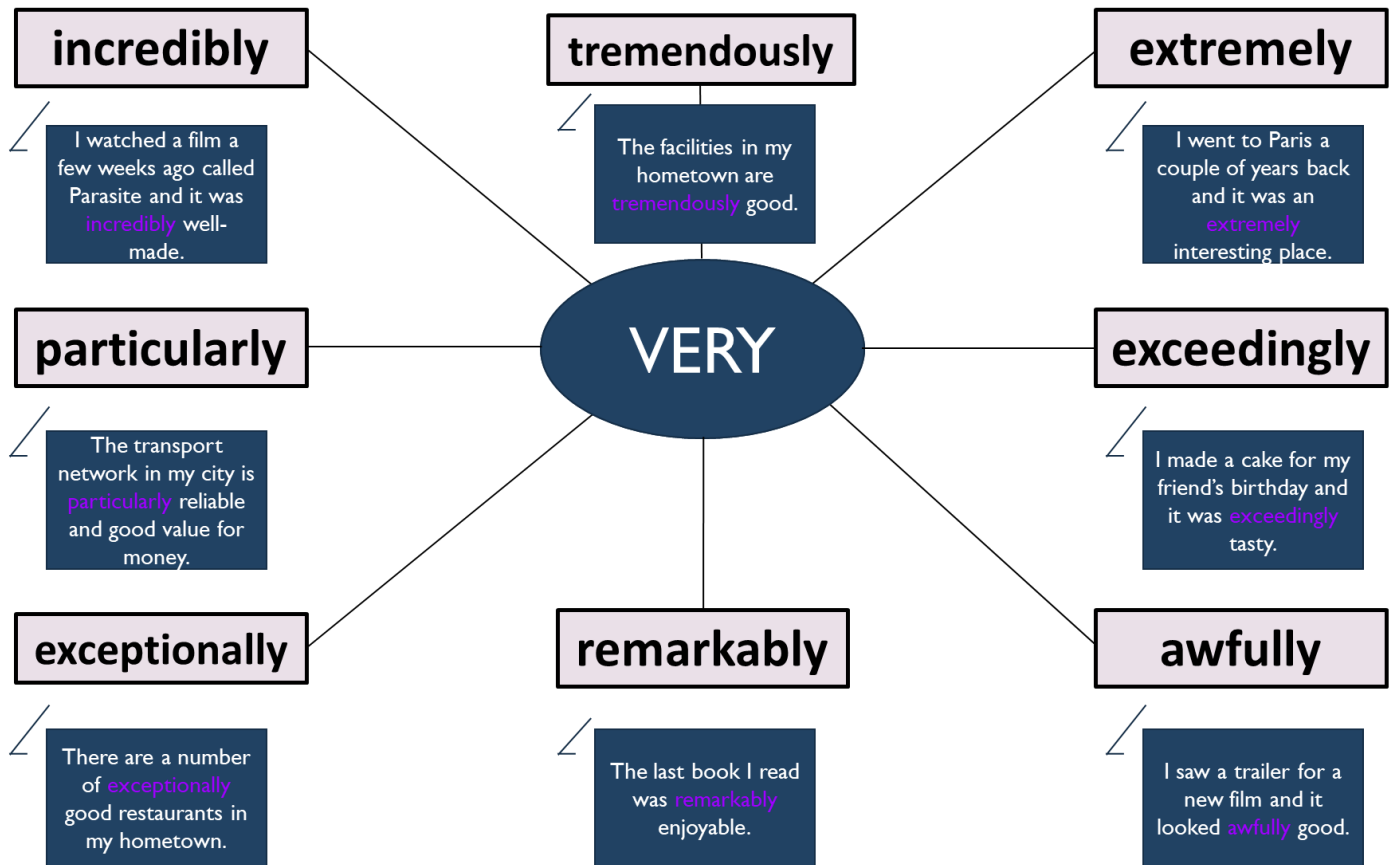


I wish/If only I could think of a more detailed answer but my mind's gone blank*.

My mind's gone blank = I've forgotten what I was going to say

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 2 — USING INTENSIFIERS



USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 USEFUL DISCOURSE MARKER — MIND YOU

How do you feel when you are waiting for someone and they are late?

- To be honest, I get extremely annoyed as being punctual is respectful and, therefore, turning up late is disrespectful. **Mind you**, since having children, I find I'm often late because I have a million things to do before I leave the house.

Did you get any pocket money when you were young?

- No, I did not and I am still about **bitter** about it! **Mind you**, my parents used to pay for everything and I never went without so I shouldn't complain.

Do you often use public transport?

- **I'm ashamed to** admit that no I don't. **Mind you**, **I live in the middle of nowhere** so my options are severely limited so I need to use my car to get around.

USEFUL PREPARATION

What do you do when you have difficulty sleeping?

- Well, there are a number of things such as reading because reading sends me to sleep and listening to a podcast because I find if I focus on someone speaking, it shuts down my brain and helps me sleep.

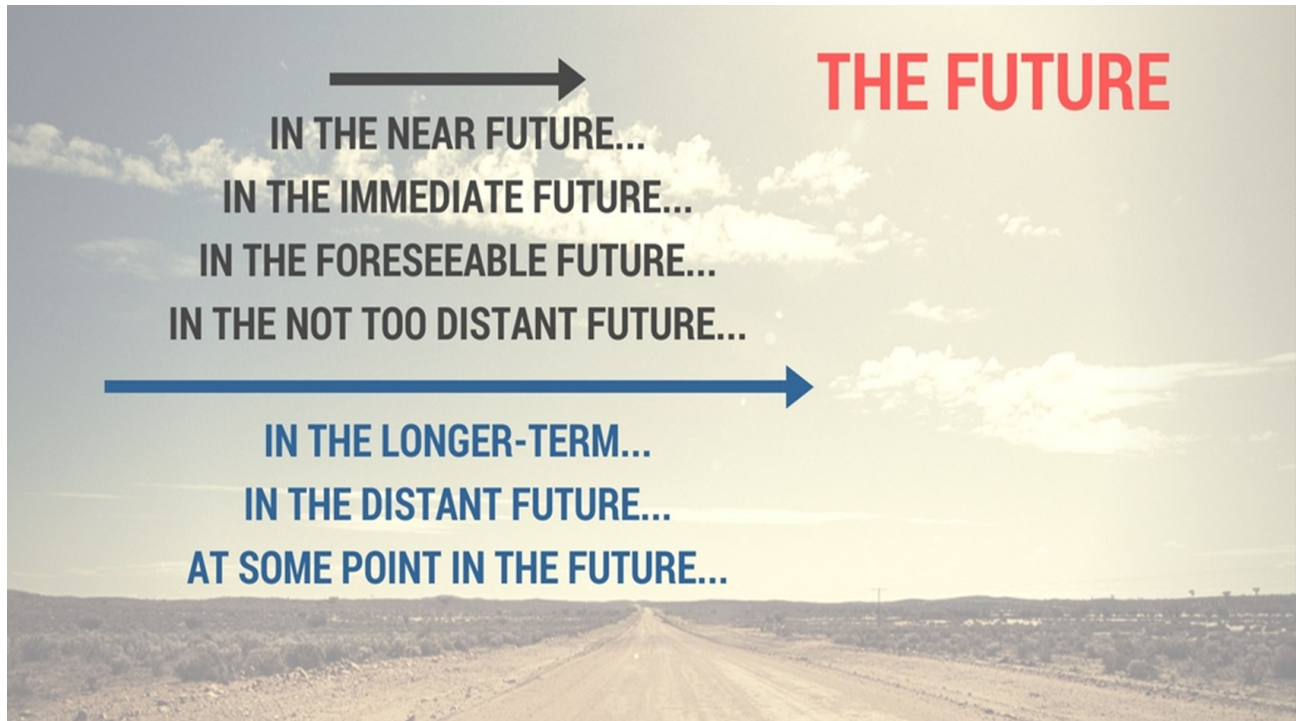
Mind you, I rarely have difficulty sleeping, I love sleeping and can **drop off** immediately.

Glossary

To turn up late	To arrive late
To be bitter about something	To be annoyed about something
To be ashamed	To be embarrassed
Severely limited	Very small
To shut down your brain	Your brain stops working/thinking about things
To drop off	To fall asleep

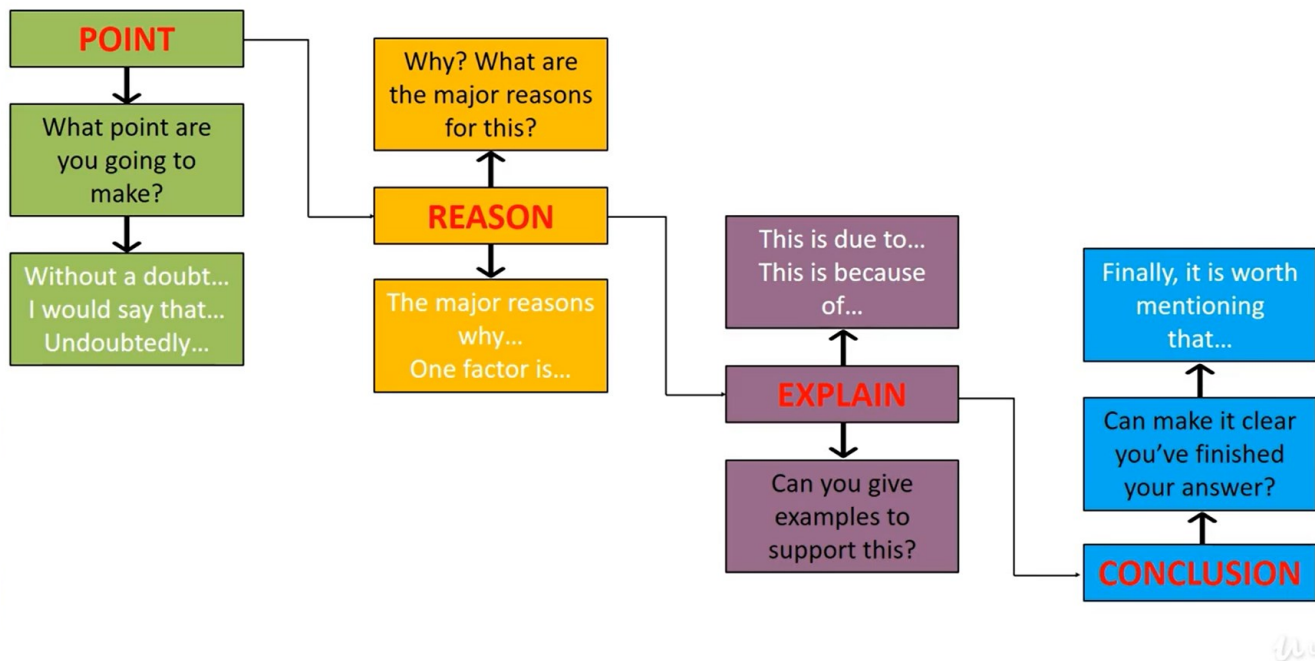
USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 1, 2 AND 3 — THE FUTURE



USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 3 — STRUCTURING YOUR ANSWER



1. What types of sports are popular in your country?

POINT

Without a doubt, football, basketball and table tennis are probably **the best-loved sports** where I live. **They are all played by** thousands, probably millions, of people.

REASON

I guess the major reason why they are so popular is to do with how easy it is to play them.

EXPLAIN

This is largely due to the fact that you don't need much **equipment** at all, which is **especially** important because in my country people **tend not to have** a huge amount of **disposable income**.

CONCLUSION

Finally, it is worth mentioning that our **top** players are international stars and probably the best-known sportsmen and women in the country. If they walk down the street, they **are recognised** by just about everyone.

Fluency and Coherence
Lexical Resource
Grammatical Range

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 3 — TALKING ABOUT ADVANTAGES/DISADVANTAGES

Noun (+)	Noun (-)	Adjective (+)	Adjective (-)
advantages	disadvantages	advantageous	disadvantageous
benefits	drawbacks	beneficial	harmful
pros	cons	positive	negative
upsides	downsides	favourable	detrimental

Examples

One of the cons of this is the fact that...

This would be beneficial because...

One of the major downsides of this is...

This is extremely favourable because...

I feel that this is largely harmful because...

One of the main snags* of this idea is...

snags* = informal language

Remember that when you use 'One of the _____', it needs to be with a plural noun e.g. One of the major **downsides** of this is...'

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 3 — USEFUL PHRASES

OFF THE TOP OF MY HEAD

(without giving it too much thought or having too much knowledge)

What kinds of people don't use the internet and what are the disadvantages of not using the internet?

Oh, that's not something I've ever given any thought to, but off the top of my head... I guess that **there might be** a large percentage of **the elderly** who do not use it. **Moreover**, in certain parts of the world, **they may not yet have** internet access. **As for the drawbacks** of this... the internet is **a huge resource**, like **a mobile library**, that you can **tap into** whenever and wherever you like so this is **definitely a handicap** for **those** without it.

BY AND LARGE

(on the whole; everything considered)

Why do some people refuse to eat animals?

Well, by and large, I guess there are three **fundamental** reasons. **Firstly**, certain religions such as Buddhism **imply** that the eating of animals is wrong. **Secondly**, some consider it **morally unacceptable** to kill animals for food. **And finally**, **health conscious individuals refrain from eating** meat because **it is considered** bad for health.

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 3 — USEFUL PHRASES

MY GUT FEELING

(an instinctive feeling, rather than an opinion based on facts)

Do you think technology has brought us closer or not?

Oh, that's not something I've ever considered before, but my gut feeling is that it probably has. I know that it could be argued that we spend far too much time on electronic gadgets and do not interact with our families as much as before; however, we can keep in touch with people who live further afield whereas in the past we might have lost touch with them.

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 3 — WAYS OF SAYING I DON'T KNOW

Which problems nowadays are solved by international organisations?

I'm not entirely sure to be honest, it's not something I've ever thought about before... I suppose they might be dealing with problems connected with internet security. Other than that, I haven't got a clue.

If someone is too organised, do you think they would find it difficult to be creative?

I'm not entirely sure how to answer that... I guess they may find it a struggle. As I'm not a particularly organised person myself, it's hard to say. However, I am not creative either so I don't think there is a correlation between the two things.

a correlation = a link; a connection; a mutual relationship

USEFUL PREPARATION

PART 3 — WAYS OF SAYING ‘I DON’T KNOW’

What aspect of culture do old buildings reflect?

It's hard to say because I'm not particularly interested in old buildings so it's not something I've ever considered. I imagine they reflect our history, but I can't really give you any good examples of how.

Ways of saying 'I don't know'

I'm not entirely sure to be honest, I guess...

I'm really sorry, but I haven't got the faintest idea*

I really haven't got a clue what to say, but here goes...

I am not the best person to answer that because I'm just not interested in...

I wish I had an intelligent answer to this question, but the honest answer is I have no idea.

*used for emphasising that you do not know or understand something:
e.g. I haven't the faintest idea what you mean

Part 1 - Hometown

What kind of place is your hometown?

Student: My hometown is a densely populated city (1) and is located in (1) the north of the country. It is renowned for (2) its bustling (3) city centre and is teeming with (4) people day and night. There is a wide range of shops, it could be described as a shopper's paradise (5), however, it isn't the most picturesque (6) place in the world and is best described (2) as a concrete jungle (7).

What are the most interesting things to do there?

Student: There are loads of great things to do there such as (1) shop till you drop (8), then followed by (2) with afternoon tea in a fancy (9) café and maybe a bit of sightseeing. I would strongly recommend visiting (3) the art gallery. There are a few masterpieces (10) in there so it's definitely worth visiting (4).

What kind of jobs do people do there?

Student: There is a mixture of (11) jobs done (5) by the people who (6) live there. Firstly (3), there is a large industrial estate (12) on the outskirts of (13) the city so many local residents (14) are employed (7) there. In addition (4), because of the increasing number of (15) shops there, a lot of the individuals (16) are employed (7) in the service industry (17).

Would you say it is a good or bad place to live?

Student: Although (5) there are drawbacks (18) of living in such a crowded and busy city (19), I wouldn't want to live anywhere else because there's always something to do. I'm

a massive fan of (20) city living so at this point in my life (21), I wouldn't want to live anywhere else. In the future, the distant future (22), however (6), I might be tempted (23) to relocate (24) to the country because I don't think the city is a place to bring up (25) kids (26).

How do you travel around your hometown?

Student: I generally tend to (27) travel around by bus. The transport network (28) is pretty good (29) and it is reasonably cheap (30). It is also quite reliable (31). Using a car is difficult because of the traffic jams (32) in the rush hour (33) and the city centre can get particularly congested (34).

Would you prefer to live in a bigger or smaller place?

Student: Despite the fact that (7) I can see the pluses (35) of living in a smaller place, such as having clean air to breathe, I absolutely adore (36) living in a city. There is no time to get bored because it literally is the city that never sleeps (37). As I get older though (8), I think I will get sick of (38) the rat race (39) and will end up (40) living in a house in the country.

Part 1 – Work

Where do you work?

Student: I work as a nurse and **am employed (8)** in a hospital in my hometown.

Do you think it is a good place to work?

Student: **Don't get me wrong (4)**, **I absolutely love (28)** my job, but the equipment in the hospital is quite **dated (29)** and this can make the job hard at times.

Why did you choose this job?

Student: I wanted to work in a **profession (30)** where I could help people. **Furthermore (5)**, I didn't want to do **a desk job (31)**. **I would be bored to tears if I had to do (9) a nine-to-five job (32)**. I like **the variety (33)** in the job I do, no two days are the same,

What do you enjoy most about your job?

Student: **As previously mentioned (6)**, no two days are the same, therefore, boredom is something I don't suffer from in my job. I get to meet **people from all walks of life (34)** and **even though (7)** there are sometimes days when it can be **tough (35)**, often people leave the hospital feeling better so I get **a feeling of satisfaction (36)** that I have helped them.

Have you always wanted to do this job?

Student: When I was younger, I wanted to be a doctor, but the thought of studying for seven years **put me off (37)**. When I left school, I got a job in an office, but I quickly realised that **I wasn't**

cut out for (38) sitting behind a desk all day so that was when I retrained (39) as a nurse. I don't regret it for a second (40).

What training did you need to do for this job?

Student: My training lasted for four years. It was a combination of (41) practical training on the job (42) and study in the classroom. I have learnt most things actually doing the job though. I feel like I am still learning (10) every day because diseases change and new drugs are developed to combat (43) them.

What are your work plans for the future?

Student: I would like to work in the UK so that is why I am taking (10) IELTS in order to meet the requirements to work there. I understand there is a nursing shortage (44) there. It has always been my dream to work in another country. If I get a job there, I will stay there for about a decade (45), then hopefully return to my home country and use the skills I have obtained to get a top job (46) back home.

Part 1 – Study

What do you study?

Student: I'm currently studying (1) on an English course in the UK. I've been studying (2) here for about six months.

Where do you study?

Student: I'm studying (3) in a further education college, which is situated in (4) the south of England.

Do you think this is a good place to study?

Student: Absolutely (1). The college is a massive (2) place with great facilities (3). There's a huge (4) well-stocked (5) library and the science labs are well-equipped (6) with the latest equipment (7). The catering facilities (8) offer a wide variety of food options and there are plenty of places to get a cheap bite to eat (9). I thoroughly enjoy studying there (10) because the teachers are warm, caring and inspiring (11).

Have you always wanted to study this?

Student: Absolutely not (12). When I was younger, like all youngsters (13) I had dreams of becoming famous, but as I grew older I became fascinated by (14) science. My science teacher in secondary school was an inspiration (15) to me and sparked an interest in (16) this subject.

What is the most interesting part of your study?

Student: I particularly enjoy (17) the practical work because it's very hands-on (18) and it is easier to understand things when you actually experience them. Generally (1), we tend to do (5) practical work once a week and theoretical stuff the rest of the time. I wish it was the other way round (19).

Is there anything you don't like about your study?

Student: The only thing that I'm really not keen on (20) about my study is the amount of homework. I'm snowed under with work (21) and it leaves me with very little time to do anything else. I used to like (6) going to the cinema regularly with my mates (22), but since starting (7) this course I spend every spare minute with my head in a book (23).

What are your study plans for the future?

Student: In the near future (2), I hope to go to university in the UK. I have applied to a number of top universities (24). In the longer-term (3), I imagine (25) I will return to my home country and I hope to get a job in the field of (26) environmental science. I'm hoping that my degree and knowledge gained in the UK will enable me to find a good job with good prospects (27).

IELTS SPEAKING BAND DESCRIPTORS

Band	Fluency & Coherence	Lexical Resource	Grammatical Range and Accuracy	Pronunciation
9	- speaks fluently with only rare repetition or self-correction - any hesitation is content-related rather than to find words or grammar - speaks coherently with fully appropriate cohesive features - develops topics fully and appropriately	- uses vocabulary with full flexibility and precision in all topics - uses idiomatic language naturally and accurately	- uses a full range of structures naturally and appropriately - produces consistently accurate structures apart from 'slips' characteristic of native speaker speech	- uses a full range of pronunciation features with precision and subtlety - sustains flexible use of features throughout - is effortless to understand
8	- speaks fluently with only occasional repetition or self correction; hesitation is usually content-related and only rarely to search for language - develops topics coherently and appropriately	- uses a wide vocabulary resource readily and flexibly to convey precise meaning - uses less common and idiomatic vocabulary skilfully, with occasional inaccuracies - uses paraphrase effectively as required	- uses a wide range of structures flexibly - produces a majority of error-free sentences with only very occasional inappropriacies or basic/non-systematic errors	- uses a wide range of pronunciation features - sustains flexible use of features, with only occasional lapses - is easy to understand throughout; L1 accent has minimal effect on intelligibility
7	- speaks at length without noticeable effort or loss of coherence - may demonstrate language-related hesitation at times, or some repetition and/or self-correction - uses a range of connectives and discourse markers with some flexibility	- uses vocabulary resource flexibly to discuss a variety of topics - uses some less common and idiomatic vocabulary and shows some awareness of style and collocation, with some inappropriate choices - uses paraphrase effectively	- uses a range of complex structures with some flexibility - frequently produces error-free sentences, though some grammatical mistakes persist	shows all the positive features of Band 6 and some, but not all, of the positive features of Band 8

PHRASES TO USE Press Esc to exit full screen TO ADD EXTRA INFORMATION

In fact...

David Beckham is incredibly famous in the UK. **In fact**, he is legendary in all corners of the globe.



In actual fact...

I'm pretty sure I wouldn't like to be famous. **In actual fact**, I'm certain, I'd absolutely hate it.



As a matter of fact...

Kids are obsessed with pointless celebrities. **As a matter of fact**, the most famous people in the world right now are social media stars.



DIFFERENT WAYS OF SAYING YES AND NO



Absolutely

Certainly

Definitely



Absolutely not

Certainly not

Definitely not

PART 3 – FLUENCY AND COHERENCE

1. What are the advantages of living in a city or big town?

Oh, well, I guess there are a number of advantages of residing in a city or town. First and foremost, there is access to local facilities. Not only do you have access to local shops, but also to the larger shopping malls in the city centre. Another significant benefit is that the transport infrastructure is better. For example, you can take public transport to work instead of using your car. A final advantage worth mentioning is that the nightlife is significantly better than in rural areas. For instance, you can go to the cinema or the theatre in urban areas. As a matter of fact, such activities are almost non-existent in rural locations.

Fluency and Coherence
Lexical Resource
Grammatical Range

IELTS SPEAKING BAND DESCRIPTORS

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IELTS SPEAKING BAND DESCRIPTORS

Band	Fluency & Coherence	Lexical Resource	Grammatical Range and Accuracy	Pronunciation
6	- is willing to speak at length, though may lose coherence at times due to occasional repetition, self-correction or hesitation - uses a range of connectives and discourse markers but not always appropriately	- has a wide enough vocabulary to discuss topics at length and make meaning clear in spite of inappropriacies - generally paraphrases successfully	- uses a mix of simple and complex structures, but with limited flexibility - may make frequent mistakes with complex structures though these rarely cause comprehension problems	- uses a range of pronunciation features with mixed control - shows some effective use of features but this is not sustained - can generally be understood throughout, though mispronunciation of individual words or sounds reduces clarity at times
5	- usually maintains flow of speech but uses repetition, self correction and/or slow speech to keep going - may over-use certain connectives and discourse markers - produces simple speech fluently, but more complex communication causes fluency problems	- manages to talk about familiar and unfamiliar topics but uses vocabulary with limited flexibility - attempts to use paraphrase but with mixed success	- produces basic sentence forms with reasonable accuracy - uses a limited range of more complex structures, but these usually contain errors and may cause some comprehension problems	shows all the positive features of Band 4 and some, but not all, of the positive features of Band 6
4	- cannot respond without noticeable pauses and may speak slowly, with frequent repetition and self-correction - links basic sentences but with repetitious use of simple connectives and some breakdowns in coherence	- is able to talk about familiar topics but can only convey basic meaning on unfamiliar topics and makes frequent errors in word choice - rarely attempts paraphrase	- produces basic sentence forms and some correct simple sentences but subordinate structures are rare - errors are frequent and may lead to misunderstanding	- uses a limited range of pronunciation features - attempts to control features but lapses are frequent - mispronunciations are frequent and cause some difficulty for the listener

USING PARAPHRASE EFFECTIVELY

My hometown
is nice. It's
big and very
nice. I really
like it.



Prepare for {IELTS}

USING PARAPHRASE EFFECTIVELY

USEFUL PHRASES FOR IELTS

TO SAY HOW MUCH YOU AGREE OR
DISAGREE WITH SOMETHING

I couldn't
agree more

I wholeheartedly
agree

I agree
to a great extent

I agree to
some extent

I completely
disagree

I completely
agree

I totally
agree

I agree to a
large extent

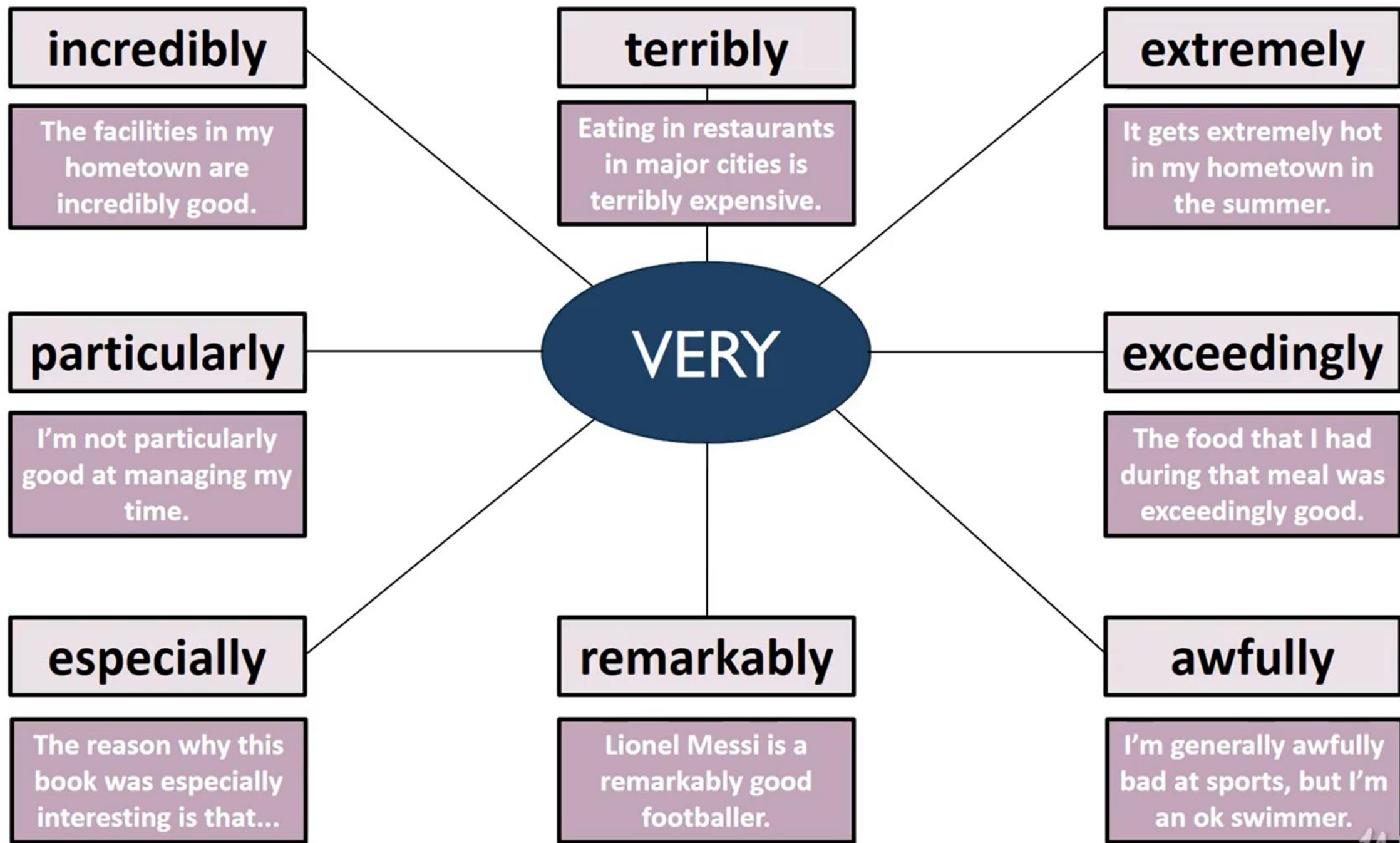
I partly
agree

I disagree
entirely

Yes, I agree
that living in
a city is
better than
living in the
countryside.



Prepare for {IELTS}



HOW TO SAY 'I DON'T KNOW'

Do you know how to make a cake?

I'm not entirely sure how to make a cake because to be honest, it's not something I've ever done before... I suppose you need eggs, flour, butter and sugar and they are mixed together. Other than that, I don't really know.

HOW TO SAY 'I DON'T KNOW'

Why do you think rich people like to eat special foods?

I'm not sure how to answer that. It's not something I've ever thought about before... I guess they can afford special food and it tastes good. As I'm not a particularly wealthy person myself, it's hard for me to say.

HOW TO SAY 'I DON'T KNOW'

How has the food we eat changed in the last 50 years?

It's hard to say because I'm not particularly interested in food so it's not something I've given much thought to. I imagine it's not as healthy as before, **but I can't really give examples of how or why.**

USING COLLOCATIONS AND LESS COMMON VOCABULARY

Collocation	Meaning	Example
to be snowed under with	to have a lot of things to do	I'm snowed under with work at the moment so I don't go to the cinema much.
a distant memory	something that you cannot remember very well because it happened a long time ago	I have a distant memory of wanting to be a doctor when I was young.
vitaly important	very important	Being able to use a computer is vitaly important in this day and age,
a vivid memory	something you remember clearly	I have a vivid memory of visiting the museum on a school trip when I was in high school.
to think long and hard about something	to consider something for a long time	I thought long and hard about going abroad to study.

IDIOMS ABOUT PEOPLE

Idiom	Meaning	Example
To be a people person	Someone who is good with people	One of the reasons why he is so successful is that he is a people person.
To be head and shoulders above the rest	To be much better than everybody else	In the world of football, he is head and shoulders above the rest.
To be a charismatic leader	Someone who has an engaging persona	It is vitally important to be a charismatic leader and not just a good organiser of people.
To be full of beans	To be full of energy	My friend is always full of beans – day and night.
To be the life and soul of the party	To like having fun	I wouldn't describe myself as the life and soul of the party, as I am quite a shy person.

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USING THE PAST SIMPLE

I would like to talk about a trip I took with my friends to the beach. My friends and I decided to go to the beach after our graduation from university since we all love swimming. One of our friends has a car, and it's big enough for the four of us. We always love to travel by car rather than public transport since being in a car means we can stop anytime we want.

We prepared a lot of food for the journey and for a picnic when we got there . We made sandwiches and salads, as well as cut up lots of fresh fruit. We also had some fish and meat because we wanted to have a barbecue on the beach. While traveling, we stopped to eat and told stories while eating. We knew that had to wake up early during the trip as it would take us many hours to reach the coast. This particular beach is stunningly beautiful so that is why we chose to go there. There is also a hotel nearby so if we wanted to stay longer, we could just go to the nearby hotel.

We travelled for four hours, and when we arrived, the sun was just rising . It was breathtakingly beautiful. We had the whole beach to ourselves as we were the first people on the beach. We enjoyed walking on the sand, and when it became hot, we swam in the water.

IMPROVE YOUR GRAMMATICAL RANGE

In the IELTS public band descriptors for **IELTS band 6** for Grammatical Range and Accuracy (Grammar) it states:

- *uses a mix of simple and complex structures*

And for Band 7:

- *uses a range of complex structures*

One way to increase your range is to use 'used to'...

IMPROVE YOUR GRAMMATICAL RANGE

1. Do you read a newspaper or read news online? Why?

A few years ago, I **used to read** a newspaper because my parents **used to buy** one everyday. Nowadays, however, I usually read the news online, as it's cheaper and more up-to-date.

used to = **used to + infinitive**

IMPROVE YOUR GRAMMATICAL RANGE

2. Do you read domestic news or international news? Why?

When I was younger, I **used to read** the domestic news, as I wasn't particularly interested in international affairs; however, as I've got older, I've become increasingly more interested in international affairs than I **used to be** so now I read both.

used to = **used to + infinitive**

PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS

Examiner: How long have you been living here?

Student: I have been living here for about three years.

Examiner: Do you work or are you a student?

Student: I am a student. I am studying economics. I have been studying this subject for the last two years.

Examiner: Can you play any musical instruments?

Student: Yes, I am learning to play the piano. I have been playing this instrument for the past five years.

Examiner: How long have you been learning English?

Student: I have been trying to learn English for the past few years, but it is only this last year that I have been focusing on it properly.

Did you go on a picnic when you were a child?

From time to time* yeah, we used to go on picnics. We tended to go on bank/public holidays when the sun was shining and my parents wanted to get us out of the house instead of watching TV 24/7.

*from time to time = occasionally; every so often

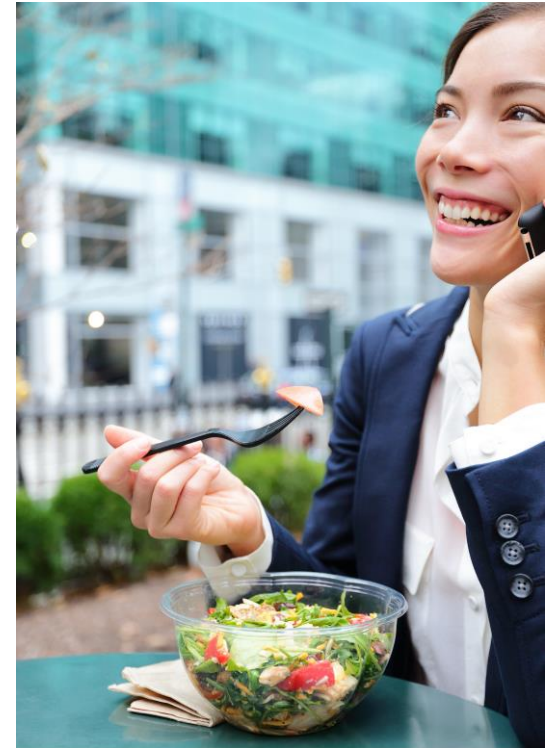
How often do you go on a picnic now?

It's not something I do on a regular basis. I guess at most I go twice a year. Rather than having a picnic, I often buy some food and go and eat it in a park to get some fresh air**. It's kind of like a picnic, but an impromptu*** one.

**to get some fresh air = to go outside

***impromptu = unplanned

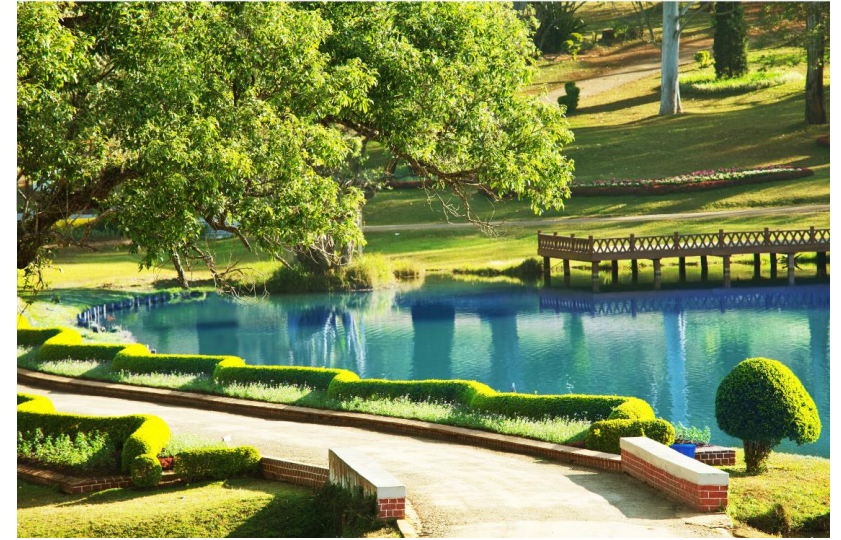
Fluency and Coherence
Grammatical Range and Accuracy
Lexical Resource



Where do you go on a picnic?

There's a **stunningly beautiful** park just round the corner from where work so **I tend to go** there in my **lunch break** **whereas** if **I'm not working**, I go to the beach or somewhere a bit further **afield***.

***afield** = away



What is the difference between a picnic and cooking at home?

Picnic food **tends to be finger food** such as **wraps** or pizza whereas when **you're eating** at home, it might be a meal with a knife and fork or chopsticks. Picnic food is **generally** cold **in contrast to** a home-cooked hot meal.



Fluency and Coherence
Grammatical Range and Accuracy
Lexical Resource

Do you like texting?

I wouldn't say it's something I particularly like, but I do like the **convenience** of being able to **fire off*** a text. It's much quicker than any other **means of communication****. I'm not a **pro-texter** though and I don't do **text talk** like **LOL**.

*to fire off a text/an email = to send something very quickly

**means of communication = methods of communication

Do you prefer sending or receiving text messages?

I don't really have a **preference**; **however**, when you get one, **the onus***** is on you to **reply** **whereas** when you send one, you can sit back and relax and wait for the **response**.

***onus = duty, burden, responsibility

Fluency and Coherence
Grammatical Range and Accuracy
Lexical Resource

LoL

bt

np

hru

txt

wat

ses

brb

2mro

H.A.N.D.

ruok

cuL8r

gr8

ttyl

4eva

m8

Have you ever received a confusing text message?

Oh yeah, **on a regular basis**. When my mum texts me, she often **clicks send** before she has finished writing it so I get half a message and **I don't have a clue*** what **she is talking about**. She's not very **tech-savvy****.

*I don't have a clue = I don't know

**tech-savvy = know a lot about modern technology



In what circumstances is making a phone call better than sending a text message?

When **you're in a rush*****. So, for example, if you need **to get hold of someone quickly to pass on****** some information or find out something then **making a quick call is preferable**.

***to be in a rush = to be in a hurry; to not have much time

****to pass on = to tell some information to someone else after you have heard it

Fluency and Coherence
Grammatical Range and Accuracy
Lexical Resource

Do you have a lot of furniture in your home?

My **style** is quite **minimalist*** so I don't have **an awful lot** of furniture. **I can't bear** lots of **clutter**** so I just have **a few key pieces**. It's much easier to keep clean and **I'm a clean freak** so this is why **minimalism** is better for me.

***minimalist** = very simple

****clutter** = lots of things making it look messy/untidy

Has anyone ever bought furniture for you?

Not that I can recall*.** In the past, people **used to give** furniture as wedding presents, but that doesn't happen nowadays and it would be quite **costly** to buy someone a piece of furniture as a birthday gift.

*****to recall** = to remember

Fluency and Coherence
Grammatical Range and Accuracy
Lexical Resource



What kind of furniture would you like to buy?

I've got my eye on* a new sofa, but I've just got a kitten and she is using my current one as a scratching post so that is out of the question** at the moment, I'm afraid.

*to have your eye on = to want

**to be out of the question = not possible



Which piece of furniture in your home do you like best?

Without a shadow of a doubt***, my bed. I love getting into bed. It's incredibly comfy and it feels like a safe haven**** for me. I can switch off from work and just chill out.

***without a shadow of a doubt = we use it when something you are saying is very true

****a safe haven = a safe place

Fluency and Coherence
Grammatical Range and Accuracy
Lexical Resource

Part 1 – Fish

Why do people go fishing?

I'm not entirely sure because it's not something I'm into myself, but I guess they find it relaxing and it's a great way to recharge your batteries*.

*to recharge your batteries = If you recharge your batteries, you take a break from activities which are tiring or difficult in order to relax and feel better when you return to these activities

Do you like eating fish?

Yes, I try to eat fish on a regular basis**, as it's healthier than meat, particularly oily fish such as mackerel and salmon.

**on a regular basis = regularly

Where can you see fish?

Well, it depends on the fish. Some live in the ocean and some in freshwater rivers, but on land the best place to see them is in an aquarium*. A lot of major cities have them.

*aquarium = sea life centre

Where do you buy fish?

Occasionally in the supermarket if I'm pressed for time**, but I prefer to get them from the market because they tend to be fresher and there is a wider choice available.

**to be pressed for time = to be in a hurry; to not have much time

Part 1 – Corona Virus

How do you feel about the corona virus outbreak?

Oh my goodness, we are living in an unreal situation at the moment. I know there were previous pandemics such as the Spanish flu, but this feels unprecedented* - it's a living nightmare. Health professionals are doing an incredible job trying to save people, but hospitals are so overwhelmed** that they cannot cope with the numbers of infected people.

*unprecedented = never done or never known before

**overwhelmed = swamped; flooded

What do people have to do during the quarantine time?

That kind of depends... if you are able to work from home, then you have to still work, mind you, this isn't an option for all. Regardless of*** your work situation, staying sane**** is a priority. Everyone's mental health will be affected during this crisis so it's essential to vary***** your activities during the day and try to do some physical exercise as well.

***regardless of = without being influenced by any other events or conditions; despite

****to stay sane = having a healthy mind

*****to vary = to change

Part 1 – Jeans

Do you wear jeans?

Yes, I do. I think they're probably one of **the most used items of clothing** in my **wardrobe**.

No, I don't. **I used to wear them** when I was younger, but I don't anymore.

How often do you wear jeans?

As often as I can really. They are **my go-to item** so I wear them anytime I can **dress casually**. **I live in them***, **to be perfectly honest**.

*To live in something means to wear it all the time
--

Do you like wearing jeans?

Yes, I do because they're **comfy** and **trendy**. **Admittedly**, they're not great to wear in hot weather, but I love wearing them when it's **chilly** because they keep me warm.

Why do you think jeans are popular in your country?

I guess that one of the main reasons is that they come in many different **styles/fits** so there is **a style/fit to suit everyone**. So, if you prefer **tight** trousers/pants, you can wear **skinny** or **slim** jeans, **whereas** if **you are into baggy clothes**, you can wear **regular** or **boot-cut** jeans.

Do you normally stay up late?

I didn't use to stay up late but since being in lockdown I've become a bit of a night owl*. I've been staying up past midnight whereas previously I used to be fast asleep** by half ten.

*a night owl = a person who tends to stay up until late at night, or the early hours of the morning

**to be fast asleep = to be in a deep sleep



When was the last time you stayed up late? Why

Like I said, I've been doing it quite a lot recently, but the last time I pulled an all-nighter was when I was studying for an exam in high school. I couldn't do it now though.

***to pull an all-nighter = to stay up all night usually studying

Fluency and Coherence
Grammatical Range and Accuracy
Lexical Resource

Did you like to stay up late when you were a child?

Well, yes I did, but my parents were pretty strict and stuck to a routine so I had to be in bed early on a school night. In the holidays, they were a bit more chilled* and let me stay up past my bedtime**.

*to stick to a routine = to keep to a routine; to do the same things regularly at the same time

**chilled = relaxed; easy-going

***past my bedtime = past the time you normally go to sleep

Fluency and Coherence
Grammatical Range and Accuracy
Lexical Resource

Part 1 – Wild Animals

Have you ever seen a wild animal before?

Yes, I have and oh... what an **incredible** experience. When **I was visiting** Australia, **we were driving** down a **pretty isolated** road and suddenly a **kangaroo hopped** in front of the car. **We were going** slowly so stopped the car and just **stared at** this amazing **creature**. **It really took my breath away***.

***to take your breath away** = astonish or shock you, with pleasure, surprise, or some other emotion

Which wild animal do you like the most?

Oh gosh, that's a tricky question because I'm an animal lover so **it's tough to pick just one...** I guess **if I had to choose, I'd go for** the panda. They're **incredibly cute** animals and **endangered**** so it's **virtually impossible***** to see one **in the wild**.

****endangered** = in danger of extinction

*****virtually impossible** = almost impossible

Do you like going to zoos?

Yes and no, it's not something I do **as a rule***; **however**, if I'm on holiday then I might go to a zoo **to pass the time****. I'm not a massive **fan of** keeping animals **in cages** in zoos, **to be perfectly honest**; **however**, if they have a **breeding programme***** for **endangered species**, then I support that.

***as a rule** = If you say that something happens as a rule, you mean that it usually happens.

****to pass the time** = to let time or a period of time go by especially while doing something enjoyable

*****a breeding programme** = the planned breeding of a group of animals or plants, usually involving at least several individuals and extending over several generations

Prepare for {IELTS}

Part 1 – Museums and Art Galleries

Do you like art?

Art is such a **broad term*** and if it includes **visual, musical and performance art** then yes, I am a massive fan of art. **If you are simply talking about** art as in drawings and paintings, then **I'm not into it** as much. **I'm more of a music lover.**

***a broad term** = includes a wide range of things

Do you have any artwork on your walls?

I have a few **prints****, not **original artworks**. I have one by... oh what's his name, **sorry the name escapes me*****... **anyway**, it's a painting called the scream.

****prints** = an art print is a reproduction of an original artwork

*****if something escapes you** = you can't remember it

Do you like going to museums?

Yes and no, it's not something I do **as a rule***; **however**, if I'm on holiday then **I make a point of going**** to museums because you get **a flavour** of the place.

***as a rule** = If you say that something happens as a rule, you mean that it usually happens.

****to make a point of doing something** = to always do something or take particular care to do something

Have you ever been to an art gallery?

Yes, I have, I've been to a few. Although I wouldn't class myself as*** an art enthusiast, I do like Van Gogh so when I was visiting Amsterdam I went to the Van Gogh museum to see his masterpieces. I was blown away****, to be perfectly honest.

***to class = to include someone or something in a particular group because they have similar features or qualities

****to be blown away = to be very impressed by something

Part 1 – Running

Do you like running?

In a word, no. I occasionally have to run for the bus when I've slept in*, but going for a fun for pleasure or to keep fit is not something I do as a rule.

*to sleep in = to sleep later than you normally do

How often do you go for a run?

Never ever**. I'm not a fan of running and, to be perfectly honest, the last time I went for a run was when I was studying in high school.

**never ever = we use this in speaking to make 'never' much stronger

Where do you usually go running?

I only run when I am running late for something such as a bus or a train. I get out of breath* and my knees hurt if I run for long so I try to avoid it.

*to get out of breath = when you have a shortness of breath and are gasping for air after exercising

Do you think running is a good way to stay healthy?

Actually, no I don't. On the plus side, it is aerobic exercise**, which is good for your heart; however, there is a lot of strain*** on the body so you can get a lot of injuries.

**aerobic exercise = aerobic exercise is any type of cardiovascular conditioning or "cardio." During cardiovascular conditioning, your breathing and heart rate increase for a sustained period of time.

***strain = pressure, demands

Part 1 – Science Classes

Do you/did you like science classes?

On the whole, I guess so. The practical lessons when we did experiments were my favourite, but I wasn't as keen on the theory lessons. Obviously, it depended on the topic, some were fascinating whereas others were tedious.

*on the whole = in general

Did you have science classes in primary school or high school?

Both, if my memory serves me right*. In primary school, we did more practical lessons and in secondary there was more emphasis/focus on the theory sadly.

*if my memory serves me right = is a way to say you think you are remembering something correctly

What kind of science did you do at school?

There was a mixture of physics, biology and chemistry. From memory, physics focused on energy, biology included animal and plant ecosystems* and chemistry covered atomic structure and energy changes, that kind of thing.

*ecosystems = an ecosystem is a community of living organisms in conjunction with the non-living components of their environment, interacting as a system.

Do you think science classes are important?

Absolutely, 100% yes. I think some topics are covered in too much depth and it would be better to have a broader, general understanding, particularly of things about the environment and how our actions are damaging it.

Part 1 – Pens and Pencils

Do you usually use a pen or a pencil?

I'd say, nine times out of ten*, I use a pen, but if I was drawing something, then I'd use a pencil because you can rub out/erase any mistakes/errors.

*nine times out of ten = on nearly every occasion; nearly every time

Which do you use more often?

On the whole, I use a pen much more frequently than a pencil because you have to sharpen a pencil so you need a pencil sharpener and I don't always have one with me.

When was the last time you bought a pen or pencil?

Off the top of my head*, I can't honestly remember. I tend to get freebies** when I'm staying in a hotel or in a meeting so I haven't bought one in ages.

*off the top of my head = If you say something off the top of your head, you say it without thinking about it much before you speak, especially because you do not have enough time

**freebies = a thing that is provided or given free of charge

What do you think if someone gives you a gift of a pen or pencil?

Look, it's the thought that counts*** so I appreciate any present I am given. And you can never have too many pens and pencils.

***it's the thought that counts = used to say that you are grateful for a gift from someone even though it is small or unimportant

Part 1 – Scenery

Is there good **scenery*** in your hometown?

When you live somewhere and have lived there all your life, I don't think you see it as **scenic** or **picturesque**, **mind you**** when my friends **from out of town** come to visit, they tell me it is.

***scenery** = the general appearance of the natural environment, especially when it is beautiful

***mind you** = but

Do you like staying in hotels with scenic views?

Absolutely yes, who doesn't? I've stayed in far too many hotels with views of the car park and **I much prefer** a **room with a view**. If there is a **balcony to admire the view**, that's even better.

Do you like to take pictures of good scenery with your mobile?

Yes, I tend to do this a lot. If there is a **stunningly beautiful sunset**, then I always try to take a photo and **post** it on Instagram.

Is there good scenery in cities?

Definitely. I'm **really into** architecture so I love **wandering around*** cities and **urban areas** looking at the buildings, both **contemporary** and **historical** buildings. Some cities are **concrete jungles**, but you can still find **beauty** in them.

***to wander around** = to walk around slowly in a relaxed way or without any clear purpose or direction

****a concrete jungle** = If you refer to a city or area as a concrete jungle, you mean that it has a lot of modern buildings and you think it is ugly or unpleasant to live in

Part 1 – Laughter

Do you like to watch TV shows or films that make people laugh?

Oh absolutely, yes I do. I'm a huge fan of comedy shows and films. Life is incredibly hectic and stressful at times so I love to chill out* watching something hilarious.

*to chill out = to relax instead of worrying or feeling anxious

Do you usually make people laugh?

I wouldn't say I'm a comedian but I have a dry sense of humour** and can be quite witty*** at times.

**to have a dry sense of humour = a person with a "dry" sense of humour often says funny things with a serious, calm expression. They don't smile, laugh, or make silly faces

***witty = using words in a funny and intelligent way

Do you think it's important to laugh with your friends?

Yes, without a doubt, this is essential. Because we're all leading such busy lives, you need to be able to let off steam* and having a laugh together is a great way to do that. Laughing releases endorphins**, which are good for you.

*to let off steam = to do or say something that helps you to get rid of strong feelings or energy

**endorphins = chemicals in the body that make you feel good

Part 1 – Numbers

What's your favourite number?

Like **the majority of** people, **I have a preference for** the number 7. I guess **it's considered** the world's luckiest number because there are seven days of the week, seven colours of the **rainbow**, seven seas, seven **continents to name but a few***.

***to name but a few** = used after mentioning a small number of people or things as examples of a larger group

Are you good at remembering phone numbers?

I used to be when we used **landlines**, but now with mobiles, the numbers **are stored** in the phone so there's no need to **memorise** them.

Do you usually use numbers?

Not much **on a daily basis, to be perfectly honest. Because of this, I tend to use a calculator app** on my phone if I need **to work out*** anything. It's a bit **lazy** but it's hard to do **mental maths** when you don't do it often.

***to work out** = to calculate

Are you good at maths?

I used to be when I was studying in secondary school/high school, but I've forgotten most of it. I'm good at **the basics**, I guess, things such as **adding, subtracting, multiplying, dividing...** that kind of thing.

Part 1 – Cake

Do you like cakes and desserts?

Absolutely! I have a sweet tooth and I can't get enough of sugary snacks and sweet stuff. Sadly, they are fattening and I have to watch what I eat and not overindulge*.

*to overindulge = to have too much of something – usually food or drink

What desserts do people in your country like?

At the moment, brownies and cupcakes are all the rage*. Cupcakes, in particular, are a bit hit with* kids because they come in different colours and flavours. They are often served at kids' parties.

*to be all the rage/to be a big hit with = to be popular

Have you ever made a cake?

Yes, a couple of times. I'm not very good at baking to be perfectly honest though because it is more scientific than cooking. You must weigh/measure all the ingredients carefully and I don't have enough patience. I prefer cooking savoury dishes* because you can be a bit more experimental with flavours.

*savoury dishes = not sweet

Part 1 – Voices

Do you enjoy recording your voice and listening to it?

Absolutely not! I can't stand the sound of my voice so this is not something I would do. When I hear it on recordings I actually **cringe!**

***to cringe** = to feel embarrassed about something **cringey** = embarrassing

Has your voice ever changed?

I'm not entirely sure to be honest. I guess it might have got deeper as I've got older. I think it was more **high-pitched** when I was younger, but **I've never really thought about it.**

Are there some people's voices you don't like?

No, I don't think so. When **toddlers are throwing a tantrum*** their screams can be annoying but it's not their voice that's the problem, it's **the high-pitched screaming that gets on my nerves***.

***to throw a tantrum** = to suddenly become angry and behave in an unreasonable way

****to get on your nerves** = to be incredibly annoying

Is your voice similar to your parents?

I guess so because we have the same **accent** so there are a lot of **similarities**. It's more like my mum's than my dad's but that's probably **due to gender**.